

Photograph by JEETIN SHARMA

The rawness of the structure became a guide rather than a problem. Parts of the old roof were preserved; deteriorating beams were reinforced or replaced. Skylights were cut into the existing roof, pulling light into spaces that had been dim and unusable. "The process became less about recreating something pristine and more about carefully revealing the character already present within the space," says Kumar. The 1,500 sq ft result—a lily pond on the rear verandah, a preserved mango tree at the heart of the landscape, the clients' book collection providing the only real colour against grey cement and raw lime plaster—feels like it grew natively on the site. A home that carries, as Kumar puts it, "A sense of memory and emotional continuity that a completely new structure could not have replicated."

Upgrading Energy Efficiency

Further north, in Gurgaon, groupDCA's project began with a 20-year-old family home that had grown out of alignment with the life inside it. Spaces had fallen into disuse; circulation routes that once made sense no longer did. The response was to work through the house carefully by rethinking the layout, untangling the services and introducing one intervention that would redefine the quality of the entire structure: a sunken courtyard carved into the basement level, bringing daylight and planting into what had been the home's most neglected space. A fabricated staircase, capped by a skylight, now draws light down through every floor.

Solar panels and a comprehensive overhaul of the home's HVAC and lighting systems now run beneath the project's restrained surface—earthy tones, exposed brick, warm joinery—and have measurably extended the building's useful life while reducing its energy demand. Saved from demolition, the house performs considerably better than it did when new.

An Innovative Shift

A few kilometres away in Gurgaon, Renesa Architecture Design Interiors was asking a different question: what a home might say to the surrounding city. The starting point was a 20-year-old concrete-and-steel residential block: structurally sound and visually unremarkable, yet spatially adequate. Renesa's response was a louvred steel exoskeleton, a new outer skin wrapped around the existing frame, its vertical fins angled to intercept the south-facing sun as it moves across the facade throughout the day. The fins create shifting patterns of light and shadow on the interior walls, open up new balcony spaces and draw ventilation through the house in a way the original structure never managed. Stand inside on a bright afternoon and the light is something the old building could not have produced: warm and in constant, quiet motion.

The structural frame the exoskeleton wraps, its concrete, its steel, two decades of embedded material, remains entirely intact. Nothing was extracted. Nothing was demolished. The building that Gurgaon would have routinely replaced is still there, carrying what it always carried and doing considerably more with it.

The American architect Carl Elefante once framed it plainly: the greenest building is the one that already exists. India's most sustainable new homes, it turns out, aren't new at all. They are old structures, carefully heard and given the chance to say something new.

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